

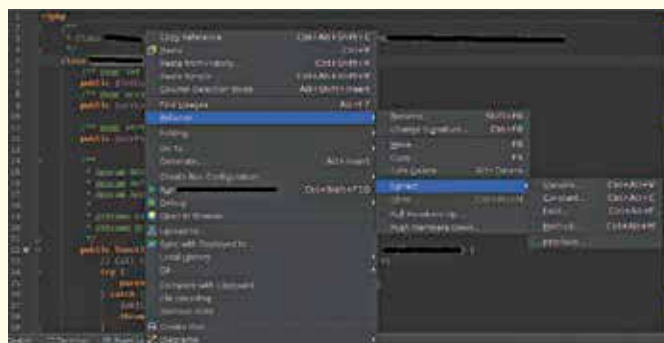
and follow up on email replies, or Buffer (<http://bufferapp.com>) that lets you pile up your tweets and status updates, only to be posted on a fixed schedule.

PHPSTORM

PHP is a popular language and there are many IDEs for PHP around. PhpStorm is one of the best IDEs for PHP. While it isn't free, the features it offers are amazing and worth the price. However, if you're a student or developer of an Open Source PHP-based project, creators of PhpStorm (Jetbrains) will give you a free license key. Installation is quite similar to that of Eclipse and you can start using it right away. The tips and tricks here will help you quickly get around. Remember that after reading what follows, other IDEs may feel more or less like Notepad. You've been warned!

Choose multiple project locations

PhpStorm allows you to create new projects from just about anywhere. You can create new projects with local files, check out from a revision control system such as Git/GitHub, Mercurial, SVN, etc., get deployed projects via FTP or even fetch files over network shares. You get this option when creating your first project or when creating a new project from existing files. You also get



Don't be overwhelmed by the vast number of options

to choose your web server configuration e.g. is it configured locally, on a remote server or not configured at all.

Set up PHP debugging

Debugging is an essential part of any type of development. PhpStorm allows you to set up debugging right away. Just make sure that a debugger is installed (XDebug is recommended). Then go to File > Settings > Project Settings > PHP > Debug > Set the debugger parameters. Restart the IDE and you're good to go. But that was just for the IDE. For the web browser, you can install 'Xdebug Helper' for Google Chrome/Chromium. Similar extensions exist for Firefox too! This is by far the easiest PHP debugging setup that we've seen.

Search for settings

If you go into your menu settings, you'll notice the exhaustive size of it. Don't let this over-

whelm you. On the left pane at the top is the settings search where you can key in the setting you're searching for, and it will take you to the related page and section. For example, if you type 'Xdebug' in the field, it will take you to Project Settings > PHP > Debug > Highlight the XDebug section on the left pane - quite useful for new users.

Inspect errors for PHP, JS, HTML, CSS and SQL code

Unlike many other IDEs which do basic type checking of PHP code, PhpStorm also understands your code. And that's not just for PHP code but also for HTML, JavaScript and CSS (and LESS, SASS, SCSS, SQL etc.).

So if you commit an error - say you try to print a variable which is undeclared (or mistyped), write non-optimised code (E.g. overwriting a variable immediately after its creation), neglect to close your HTML tags, forget a semicolon

in a CSS file, write a longer styles rule when a simpler one is available, or create a nested if-else ladder where some code becomes non-reachable - PhpStorm will inspect your code for all of them and report them to you. The IDE detects a large number of simple and small yet common mistakes you commit as a web developer and reduces the time and frustration usually spent on mundane mistakes. All you need to do is to go to Settings > Project Settings > Inspections and turn on the settings you think you need for each supported language.

Use code refactoring to replace and move files around

It's not easy to get everything correct the first time and we'll all want to change variable names, move files, rename classes, functions and parameters at some point of time. While find-replace is supported by most IDEs, that isn't how it should be done; you might end up with a broken query or an accidentally renamed class. With PhpStorm, you can right-click the variable, parameter or class name and then select Refactor -> Rename (or just press [Shift]+[F6]) and the IDE will inspect all the places where the class has been used and rename those instances. You need not worry about anything else changing.

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